AI | Expert Insights

COMPANY DEEP-DIVE

Former Principal Product Manager at Apollo.io Believes Clay Leads Go-to-Market Tech Innovation with AI and Orchestration

DATE PUBLISHED	INTERVIEW DATE	EXPERT PERSPECTIVE	ANALYST PERSPECTIVE	PRIMARY COMPANY
25 Sep 2026	22 Sep 2026	Competitor	Investor-Led (Buy-Side)	CLAY

SMART SUMMARY

Summary

The interview covered the evolution of the go-to-market technology landscape, focusing on Clay's product differentiation, competitive positioning, and adoption dynamics. Discussion included Clay's innovation in orchestration and AI, its impact on sales team structures, and the risks and opportunities facing the platform as it scales.

EXPERT BACKGROUND

- Former Principal Product Manager at a leading B2B sales engagement and data provider, with over five years of experience in product management and deep exposure to the go-to-market software and sales intelligence tool market.

EXPERT SENTIMENT

- **The expert views Clay as the primary innovator in the go-to-market technology space, having successfully** differentiated itself through orchestration and AI capabilities.
- The expert believes Clay's continued innovation and community engagement have made **it a market leader, but notes potential risks from both large platform competitors and emerging AI agent tools**.
- **The expert is optimistic about Clay's growth prospects, especially in the enterprise segment, but sees possible challenges in retaining SMB customers** as AI agents become more capable.

TAKEAWAYS

- Clay's initial breakout was due to its orchestration layer (Clay Tables) that allowed users to aggregate multiple data providers, solving the problem of fragmented data sources.
- Clay's AI Columns feature enabled scalable research and personalization, further differentiating the platform and allowing users to qualify and personalize outreach at scale.
- The platform's stickiness is high, with customers able to reduce team size and increase efficiency by centralizing workflows, though **the learning curve remains steep for less technical users**.
- **Clay faces competition from both traditional sales engagement/data providers and new AI agent tools like Claude, which can replicate some features at smaller scale but lack Clay's orchestration at enterprise scale**.
- **Clay's defensibility is rooted in its continuous innovation, community-driven template ecosystem, and ability to serve as a control layer for best-in-class tools, but there is risk from large platforms** replicating its functionality.

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Expert Bio

Former Principal Product Manager, Growth at Apollo.io. Expert can speak about Clay and their recent valuation as well as to the competitive landscape and strategic positioning of sales engagement platforms, leveraging their current role at Apollo.io and extensive experience in the industry. Former Senior Principal Product Manager, Growth at Apollo.io. Reporting to a Vice President of Growth, the expert is a growth-focused product manager responsible for A/B experiments and optimizing various parts of the Product-led growth funnel

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using data-backed, user feedback-driven insights. Prior to Apollo, the expert was a Senior Manager, Growth at Flipkart, leaving in January 2021. The expert was part of the core team that launched the product & was responsible for User Growth, Product Marketing & Analytics.

Interview Transcript

Client 00:00:00

Hi. Appreciate you making the time for our call today. To give you some quick background or context here, we are working on a research project to learn more about the sales intelligence tool market, and given your background, thought you would have a helpful perspective on some of the questions we had. Just to get started or kick things off, what would be helpful would be if you could just spend a minute or two on your background and talk a little bit more about your exposure across sales engagement and go-to-market software.

Expert 00:00:31

Sounds good. I was a principal product manager at Apollo.io, **which is a leading** sales engagement and data sets provider, B2B data provider for users. It's one of the biggest ones for small businesses, and I was there for about five and a half years. I quit last month. I am now working on my own start-up, which is in the go-to-market space itself. Let me know if you want me to tell you anything else.

Client 00:00:59

That's helpful context. One of the companies that had come up that we wanted to learn more about in particular was Clay. From your product role and maybe your time now working on the start-up, how closely have you followed Clay? How would you define the market they actually compete in today?

Expert 00:01:18

We have been tracking Clay pretty closely over the last few years because they have really taken off where three or four years back, they were not that popular, but now they are seen as the primary innovators in the go-to-market space. Definitely one of our top competitors on our radar. How I would describe it, it is more of an orchestration layer between the different tools. **One of the biggest problems in the revtech or** the go-to-market tech space is that there are just too many tools that you need to actually connect to do modern go-to-market.

Starting from your CRM, your data provider, or if you have multiple data providers, your sales engagement tool, and if you have an AI, you plug that in. Clay is trying to become the orchestration layer where you can connect all of these tools into Clay, and you then do your go-to-market plays within Clay. Versus a lot of other players are trying to be, including Apollo, an all-in-one player, trying to play in all markets themselves, versus **Clay has figured out its own niche and become really, really good** at being that orchestration layer where you can connect all these tools and that becomes your control center for your go-to-market plays.

Client 00:02:33

Right. Who do you view as Clay's most relevant competitors today? Given Clay's approach is this connector level where there are actually underlying data providers that work with them, but in some ways are competitors?

Expert 00:02:48

I would say in the most recent context, Claude would be their biggest competitor because they are now playing the same role where you bring in all your tools and connect it into Claude, and you can orchestrate a lot of things within Claude. Going a little back, I would say pretty much they started as being the orchestration layer, but they've started doing more as well. They launched their own sequencer or their campaigning tool, so they are now in direct competition with sales engagement providers like Outreach, Salesloft.

They also have their database, which is not their main strength, so they mainly rely on providers, but they do compete in that space. They are competing with all of these in a bit of a way, but they've been able to carve out a niche where they still work with all of them, and if you cannot afford a bunch of these tools, they also have their own version of it, which you can get from Clay itself.

Client 00:03:41

Right. I know you mentioned in recent years, Clay has really broken out, so maybe to spend some time understanding why that has been the case. I know you mentioned it a little bit on your control plane approach or control layer, and you mentioned that **they are unusually successful at using AI within go**-to-market. Could you just spend a little bit more time going into just what has Clay specifically done differently from the rest of the market? Even before **AI became such an important part of their product, what was the original problem** they were solving better than some of the existing competitors?

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Expert 00:04:17

Sure. The first product which really broke out was Clay Tables, which became the orchestration layer. The problem they were solving back then was you needed multiple data providers to have a most complete data set. **The problem** was there were 20 different data providers in the market, and if you want to reach 100% of your TAM, you need at least three to four different data tools. Some data providers would have data for a certain part of the market. **Someone would be strong in EU,** and you had to buy multiple subscriptions and then push all of that data into your CRM.

Clay solved that problem with their table, where you could connect multiple data providers into their own table and what they coined the term was waterfall enrichment back in the day. That was their breakout product where all of the different providers, like the more entrenched ones like Apollo and ZoomInfo, were focusing on building their own data set.

Clay went in the opposite direction saying that "You know what? You could bring your own key," or, "I have partnerships with these data providers. You don't need to buy a subscription." You could have the most complete data set in one place. Once you build that, you can push it to your CRM if you want. That orchestration part of just the data being the most complete, was their initial breakout product.

Client 00:05:40

Yeah. For that multi-provider waterfall enrichment model, why do you think

Clay was able to become the marketplace or platform for that? Did it start out as the bring your own data where if you as a company had Apollo.io and ZoomInfo, you could then plug in that account to Clay and use Clay or was it always the case that you were buying it through Clay?

Expert 00:06:05

They had two models. One is that you get a certain amount of Clay credits, and you can use those credits to buy from their partner data providers. If they don't have all the partners and you want to bring your own subscription, you can also bring your own API key. Apollo did not partner with them initially, and ZoomInfo did not because they saw them as a direct competitor. Gradually, **Clay became so popular** that all these players are now direct partners and you don't have to buy all these subscriptions. You can directly use Clay credits to use all these different data providers, so you don't need to buy multiple subscriptions.

Client 00:06:44

Got it. It sounds like the other competitors or data providers were resistant, but Clay just got enough adoption to force their hand in becoming partners over time.

Expert 00:06:54

Mm-hmm.

Client 00:06:56

Today, where is the real value sit? Is it in the underlying data or is it in Clay's ability to actually orchestrate that and use AI and actions together with the data?

Expert 00:07:07

Yeah. I think **the next product was really their true breakout** or they are the true innovators was they were able to use the same model that they use for data and they use it in AI. They launched something called AI Columns, which is basically if you have a row and in the initial days, you could only do so much research on a prospect as the number of filters or the structured data there is with data providers.

An example for that is if I am researching X person, I can only look at 40 attributes that Apollo gives me. If I am looking for something else like, is this company a B2B or a B2C company, and that filter does not exist on any of the data providers, Clay was able to get me that data using the AI column where I could query, is this a B2C or a B2B company? You could do that at scale at 50,000 rows at a time.

That way you can use it for two reasons. One is a qualification layer, and the second is a personalization layer. This means using this AI research, you can actually ask questions to AI about the prospect or the company, which would help you then qualify a lead if they are truly fit in your persona that you are selling to. The different kind of research would be, what are their pain points? You use that to personalize your email or the communication that you are going to send out. Does that make sense?

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Client 00:08:33

Yeah, that does. Today, how much of Clay's overall success would you attribute to still having some sort of superior technology compared to things like the product design or user interface and the community and branding that built up over time?

Expert 00:08:48

I would say it's a mix of a lot of things. I think one is that they are still riding on being that innovator, that this is how GTM is to be done. They are still seen as the market leaders in that way. Every time they do something, they have a community that listens to them and follows them. I think two is that they've created a lot of templates on how to do certain things, and they've tapped into their community on how they are using Clay and get them to share with the broader audience. They have a library of templates where you can just clone it and start your own GTM play.

This was a very simple example I gave you on the B2C versus a B2B. There are very specific and complex industry-specific researches that people do to personalize emails and all of that thing, like did this person come on a podcast, bring in their LinkedIn post, and all of that stuff. As someone who is new to sales, you might not know what to do, but Clay has really enabled that.

Plus, they keep coming with new launches as well, which are not a me-too kind of a product. They are really out there. An example of that is they recently launched their Ads portfolio, which is not really into sales, but still in the go-to-market space, where if you have a database of emails, you can qualify some of them and convert those email IDs into Meta ad IDs or LinkedIn ad IDs and create a LinkedIn campaign even from there. You can orchestrate much more complex campaigns as well. I think their ability to continuously innovate in the space has really been, like people really stop and notice what they are doing.

Client 00:10:31

Right. I know this is a little bit difficult since it's a platform and there is a benefit to having a complete thing altogether. Just to understand the technical or product differentiation a bit more, if you split Clay out into a couple buckets, data aggregation, workflow automation, AI research and execution, which of those components do you think are truly differentiated today, and which parts might be relatively straightforward for another well-funded competitor to reproduce or recreate?

Expert 00:11:01

Got it. The data orchestration layer is now a little more commoditized, where even Apollo has gotten into it. There are budget providers like FullEnrich who natively give you a single waterfall enrichment in an API. The innovation in the waterfall enrichment is really fading. The execution layer is the real meat, where you can actually orchestrate a set of really complex workflows in it still because there are so many connectors that are natively integrated into that.

I think the third thing you said was the AI personalization. I think with Claude, a lot of people see that as a risk for Clay as well, that maybe it won't be as differentiated. You can actually do a similar thing if you don't have thousands of prospects. You can actually do the same thing on Google Sheets now, query Gemini, and it would populate things in your Google Sheet. All of them put together is still a powerful thing that you don't have to jump between different tools. The all-in-one aspect, I think, still has value.

Client 00:12:04

Yeah. The platform makes sense on being valuable for being the main control layer. From what you have seen or heard from folks, does Clay become more defensible as customers do engage with it to build more workflows on the platform or are those workflows relatively portable if you did want to move off of Clay and use another solution?

Expert 00:12:24

I think it's pretty sticky from what we have heard. People who get into Clay really love Clay and don't want to use anything else after that, because one, they don't have to use all of these different tools, like 10 different tools. All they need to do is sign up and connect, and they are done. They just need to learn one single interface. That just removes the learning part of it from the process. I think generally companies love it as well because they have been really able to reduce their size of the teams.

I have spoken to customers who have gone down from a team of 10+ to now just two people managing Clay, where the team of 10 was doing a lot of manual work and manual research and stuff. They've been able to do more with a smaller team because they've built these workflows, and all they need to do is just manage them rather than having to create new campaigns every now and then, which they had to do earlier in the traditional sequencing and all of that.

Client 00:13:23

Right. Makes sense. I know you mentioned today some of the tools from the foundation models actually being potential competitors themselves. Putting that aside, as the foundation models improve, do you think that expands Clay's advantage because the platform can

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utilize them to orchestrate better models or does it reduce the advantage because competitors might be able to build similar capabilities faster by leveraging the foundation models?

Expert 00:13:50

I don't think Clay needs better models. The models they have are already pretty good. Even a Sonnet or even a Haiku could do pretty decent at some of the basic stuff. Going back to my previous example, the B2C versus a B2B, you don't need a better model for you to query that. I don't think Clay would benefit from being a better frontier model or with better frontier models plugged into it. However, as the frontier models get better and their context windows become larger, they would be able to do a lot more of what Clay is doing.

Right now, you can do it in a small scale. If you are a small company and you want to give me 10 VP of sales, in the California area, it would give you can connect your data provider, it will enrich the list there itself and write cold emails there itself and push it to your sequencer. You can do all of that, but if you want to do it at scale, you still won't be able to do that, at least deterministically. The quality would deteriorate of the conversation.

If you are a small company who is sending 20 emails per day, you don't need a Clay to do that. You can still connect everything into Claude or ChatGPT, achieve a similar outcome, but if you are looking at mid-market and upmarket enterprise customers who need real volume and control over how everything is happening, I think Clay is the place to be.

Client 00:15:16

Got it. I saw also in, I think, one of the responses to one of the screening questions received that **you mentioned usability as a bigger weakness for Clay**. What makes the product difficult for less technical users, and how steep do you think the learning curve is before someone actually becomes productive using Clay?

Expert 00:15:36

Got it. **They became really popular** because agencies started adopting them, and they started rebranding themselves as Clay agencies and exclusively building on Clay. They were playing on that persona a lot more than a sales rep or individual coming in and doing stuff for their own. That still exists. They are much better than what they were two years ago. If you go in, you would still have a lot of material, a lot of videos, a lot of templates at you. If you do want to learn, it's much easier for you than it was two years ago, but you still need to know what you are doing otherwise, when you log in, you are just staring at a blank table.

If you have actually gone and done your Clay University videos and all, you would know that you need to now go and set up connectors, fill up this prospect table from one of your data providers and how to build those workflows, or just look at templates and build those workflows, but you still need to know where to look. It's not a click, click, and you are done kind of a thing. You either know what is happening or you need to spend the time to watch and learn from all the material that they have provided.

Client 00:16:51

That makes sense. For the adoption today of Clay for customers, how important is it to have a dedicated, I know terms like go-to-market engineer title or similarly technical RevOps person? Do you think that creates a ceiling on the addressable market for Clay, or over time will they continue to abstract some of the complexity from the product?

Expert 00:17:15

From what we have seen so far, what has happened is that people who had SDRs are now converting into go-to-market engineers. That kind of shift was already happening, where earlier, like five years back, there were the 16, 20-member SDR teams doing research manually and sending out sequences to smaller audiences by doing their own research, having really small lists and campaigns attached to them, to moving on to larger lists and trying different ways of personalization, and fewer people doing more. I think with Clay it is possible to do, like one or two people can handle the workload of what earlier 15 or 20 people used to do.

In terms of the addressable market, in terms of number of people using Clay, might be limited, but the number of companies using Clay, I think, would still go up, because as more and more modern go-to-market teams convert from traditional to modern go-to-market teams, Clay is seen as the default way of how you become a modern go-to-market team. Apollo is also playing in that zone somewhere and is becoming more of a modern tool, but Clay is, I would say, still the default on how you make that shift.

That's happening across the market segments, which is interesting, where smaller teams are also, once they need scale, move to Clay from only their different tools. Enterprises are also now looking at either cutting their bills, unifying their tools, or different reasons, but still looking at Clay and the adoption is going up on both spectrums of the market.

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Client 00:18:46

Got it. Going back to the point around the go-to-market engineer title, I think I also saw you mention that that transition from more traditional SDRs towards the go-to-market engineer was already underway before Clay really popularized the term. What was driving that shift in the market or in certain organizations?

Expert 00:19:05

I think one reason was that a lot of these workflow tools were also coming up, people were using Zapier to run some of their automations. Even traditional data providers were becoming richer, so you could have more personalization. For example, Apollo went from maybe 25 attributes to 50, 60 attributes. You could really now start playing into personalization without having to manually research these accounts that you were earlier targeting. **That kind of shift was already happening where there was a pressure** to do more with less people and adopt these systems.

I think **Clay just captured that sentiment and gave people a real platform to do that versus using hacky ways or vanilla personalizations** to actually have a platform where they could do that personalization. That started with data and then flowed into AI. Even with data, you could have three different providers giving you more attributes, so that you have more attributes against one person even within the pre-AI era. **That itself was a big win in those days**.

Client 00:20:10

With some of the shift now and more automations coming in to the job, how **significant of a reduction in traditional SDR type of headcount** do you think could be realistic for many organizations? Is it more like the traditional SDR role is just re-scoped to a different role, but there is not actually less headcount?

Expert 00:20:29

There are still companies who have traditional SDRs, like the larger companies. That's a dying role. For example, at Apollo, we had a team of about 15 people. Now, we have just two go-to-market engineers who are probably sending out a much higher volume of emails than the SDRs were doing back in the day. It's also a shift where smaller companies or SMBs and mid-markets have made that shift much more quickly versus enterprise companies are still taking their time.

Some companies still have a mix of SDRs and go-to-market engineers, where they still want their largest accounts or their key accounts to be managed manually, where their entire job is to actually go in and research, mail one person a day, or not mail one person a day, but just do 20 emails per day. The other thing, which I forgot to mention, was that some SDRs are also taking on a cold caller role, where they are doing both email and cold calling, and that's what the role has become for some places.

Yes, there are still SDRs out there in the market, but people who are doing just plain vanilla sequencing are transitioning, or some are transitioning to an actual account executive role. The SDR teams are transitioning into where it's a volume play, it's completely go-to-market engineers. There are SDRs in larger companies, and then there are SDRs also doing cold calling. That's how I see it.

Client 00:21:57

Got it. Going back to the go-to-market engineer title, are you seeing that as more of a broadly established role across companies, or has that primarily been something that has been adopted by more tech-forward organizations?

Expert 00:22:11

I would say it's still a tech-forward kind of a deal. I will give you an example of Apollo, where we were seeing companies that are very sophisticated with go-to-market and having a RevOps person, a go-to-market engineer, and all of that. On the other side of the spectrum, we were still seeing people who have never used a sequencer in their life, and people from manufacturing companies and real estate and all those traditional industries, and they still need some kind of a go-to-market service.

Since they don't need volume, they don't have a go-to-market engineer. They can still afford to go after fewer clients and use either manual emailing or a semi-automated or just a vanilla sequencer and don't need too much, like that level of personalization and that level of data. They are okay with, "Okay, I got 80 people out of 100 that I was looking for. That is good for me." On the traditional side of it, they don't need that level of sophistication. That will be over-engineering for them.

Client 00:23:15

I see. Going back to some of the competitive dynamics, I know historically we talked about Clay kind of sit alongside the existing databases and some of these other sales engagement products, and it was really the centralized control plane layer. As they add additional features or capabilities like Sequencer, Audience, or Ads and Agents, how does that change their position in the overall tech stack for sales or go-to-market, and are they becoming more directly competitive over time or less with some of these other players?

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Expert 00:23:46

They are definitely becoming more competitive as time is passing. They didn't have a sequencer until a year, a year and a half back. They were integrating with these providers to actually send out the emails with Instantly and Smartlead, and all of that. Like I said, there are some people who don't need that level of sophistication, so for them, they have built a basic sequencer. I think they have even done that for data where they have their own set of data which they offer for cheaper before you actually go onto Waterfall.

They've actually been becoming more competitive in the places that they had all these partnerships in. Having said that, I don't think that's their primary focus on being the best sequencer tool out there. They still see themselves as a platform in all of this, and they are expanding the platform capabilities, like going from RevOps into now with the marketing, with the ads thing, they are also bringing marketing in. I think they are still focused on the platform play, but still getting more competitive with these partners.

Client 00:24:44

Yeah, if customers ultimately want a more integrated go-to-market platform, or I should ask, is that what you think customers ultimately want, or will they continue to assemble more best-of-breed products with this orchestration layer, tying things together?

Expert 00:25:00

The larger companies who can afford these different tools, **they would always want the best in the market, given that now their orchestration problem** is solved. Where earlier they still had multiple tools, but they were loosely tied with integrations, and if one integration broke, **your entire data pipeline could be corrupted**. **That problem** is what Clay has solved, and I think the upmarket would still stick with that because they want the best sequencer tool, they want the best data providers, they want the best customer recording tool.

I think they would still stick with their tools and use Clay as a platform, versus some of the smaller players, the SMB market, who does not need to have. If they can get three or four customers in a month, they are happy with that, versus someone who is sending hundreds of thousands of emails and even 1% or 2% difference is hundreds of thousands of dollars in their case, so they still care about having the best tools and integrated to Clay, but the smaller ones might be more okay with having an all-in-one play with Clay.

Client 00:26:03

Do you see **it being a big risk for Clay** that one of these large platforms, whether it be a ZoomInfo or even a Salesforce or HubSpot, replicate enough of their functionality to reduce the need for a separate Clay deployment?

Expert 00:26:17

I think that's definitely a risk. There are even other go-to-market players which are anyway trying to expand their TAM. I certainly believe HubSpot or Apollo or any of the sequencer providers could build a part of what Clay is building, especially in the sales domain. That's definitely possible. It's been two, two and a half years, no one has been really able to crack the exact formula of what Clay is doing, and that is sort of been their thing, that they are always.

Their feature set is never stale, they keep launching these new improvements and listen to their customers, keep building what they want. They have been able to keep their customers, even though these players have launched a similar or some version of what Clay has in terms of if you look at raw feature set. Yeah, all of these players have tried to build a version of it, but **no one has really been successful on the secret sauce**.

Client 00:27:11

That makes sense. I wanted to go back to the point **you had made around some of the competition** actually coming from some of the foundation model tools like Claude today. Could you just talk a little bit about how people are utilizing those tools to replicate perhaps some of the functionality they were otherwise getting from Clay? Is it all parts of Clay's business **that are being impacted,** or are there just certain features that other people are using these AI tools to replicate?

Expert 00:27:39

It's more than the feature set. It's about the outcome that you are able to orchestrate with your AI agent or your coding agent. Instead of having to do everything in Sheets and everything, all you need to do is if your GitHub is connected with your product, you don't even need to do You just can prompt it, "Help me find customers for my product," and it would come up with a set of filters, send it to your data provider, bring in these many people are there, and then you can further ask it to filter further or do all of the stuff like in natural language without having to learn a UI.

What you would do in AI research in columns, multiple columns, you could just say that "Look at everything this person has done online and give me a personalized message of what my product and you already know context of my product, give me a cold DM of what I should send

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here." Your sequencer is already connected there, and you just send it out. You basically push your contact and your content to them, and you are done. Without all that complication, you can still achieve what you can do on Clay at scale without all the complexity.

At least for now, you can do it at a smaller scale on your coding agent or your AI agent, like Claude, without complicating it, where AI does the heavy lifting for you in terms of what you need to think. That's really a game changer for someone who doesn't know sales or how this modern go-to-market stack works. All they need to do is prompt in natural language that get me 10 customers. These are the three connectors, then use context from my code base of what I am selling.

It wouldn't be the most sophisticated where you have six different columns, each referring to each other, like on Clay, but it could still get the job done with lesser effort and maybe lesser efficiency, which is good enough for someone whose main job is maybe, let's say, founder-led sales kind of a thing or a small sales team who doesn't have a RevOps person or an experienced go-to-market engineer, which is expensive. They could still achieve the similar outcomes at a smaller scale.

Client 00:29:44

Do you see that progressing over time to be more competitive with large-scale use cases as well or do you think Clay will retain an advantage in that type of workflow or use case?

Expert 00:29:54

I don't think people would be able to replicate everything in their coding agent for especially when you are working at scale. I still do see a version where it's very defensible. I do see a world where people also connect Clay into their Claude. Since, like I said, **their UI is a little complex and difficult** to learn, Claude basically does a bunch of stuff and fills it in. A human can verify everything that is on Clay and then Claude itself tells you, "Okay, go refer this template and apply it there," or apply it for you there, maybe. You are still in Claude, but more things are happening on Clay as well. I definitely see that happening as well.

Client 00:30:36

That makes sense. Also, in terms of customers trying to understand the value **they are getting from Clay, is that ROI** something that is easy for them to try to quantify? Where is the value coming from in that calculation, if so?

Expert 00:30:53

Back in the day, it was that you could cut off multiple data providers and you could get a higher quality outcome, where you could probably afford two or three subscriptions. Now, you can get access to 20 data providers, and you have a better coverage of your data. That was the first way that you could see value from Clay. Once the AI stuff came in, that was pretty easy, that you could achieve similar or better outcomes with a lesser number of people.

You don't need that big of a team, and **you have a cost advantage**. Plus, with the personalization getting better and better, **you could actually get better outcomes because there is no human error chances** there. You could theoretically achieve better outcomes if you have an experienced go-to-market engineer in a lower cost.

Client 00:31:40

I see. Saving on the data access side, but getting better data to hopefully increase your outcomes. The other thing I wanted to talk about was, obviously, over the last year or two, **Clay has gotten a lot of traction on both raising funds, but then its valuation seeing a jump** as well, with the most recent raise now just over a $7 billion valuation. What does that type of valuation tell you about the expectations being placed on the business? To grow into that scale that investors are expecting now, do you think **Clay needs to mainly focus on winning new customers** or driving greater spend with existing customers, either through selling some of the existing solutions or expanding more into the overall go-to-market stack?

Expert 00:32:27

Yeah. I think one thing there is a lot of enthusiasm in the market about, there are these players **which are leading AI innovators in each of those spaces**, each of their respective spaces, and go-to-market has no one except Clay is the clear innovator in the go-to-market space who is using AI properly, so that, if there is any money, VC money, going into the go-to-market space, that is by default now going into Clay.

About a year and a half, two back, when the first AI moment was happening, there was a bunch of AI SDR tools that came in, and **they failed on their promise**. Their promise was you just enter your website, we will scrape your website, we will tell you the leads, we will write the message, and we will just tell you the people who have positive replies. That promise failed. I think ***AI SDR*** not doing well, ***11x*** not doing well. Now by default, any VC money that needs to go into the go-to-market space is going to Clay.

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That explains some of the enthusiasm where they have actually delivered on the promise, and **they have grown 100%** or more year over year for the last three years, and build that community who really swears by Clay. That is one. Two, they continuously launch new products, which they are not really copying from anyone. They are really innovating, listening to customers and seeing what they are doing and building on top of their platform.

I think your follow-up question was what do they need to do to grow into this valuation? I certainly think they need to sell more to existing customers and win more enterprise customers. My view is that **they might lose the SMB space**, to an extent, who don't need that level of sophistication which their AI agent might now be able to provide, or very soon will be able to provide in the next few months. Let me know if you want me to go deeper into any of them.

Client 00:34:23

It's a good point on they have captured all the attention for investors looking at the go-to-market space because they have been executing well. As you look over the next, let us say, three to five-year period, what would you try to watch to determine whether Clay is really becoming this durable go-to-market platform rather than just an unusually successful point solution?

Expert 00:34:45

I think I would like to see that if they are actually able to expand into other areas of go-to-market really well. Right now, they do outbound really well, maybe they can do something with inbound marketing as well, and more on marketing, and account expansion maybe. I don't think they do much on a post-sale basis right now. They could expand into all of these areas and become a default platform for the entire revenue organization. That is something that especially I was thinking they would actually go deep into the sales space, but when they launch marketing, I think their view is to become this platform for revenue teams, and whether or not this plays out would be an interesting thing to watch out for.

I think the second would be how they react to the whole AI Agents natively getting better. How do they react to it? Are they able to either launch something new which still keeps them competitive or work with them in a better way to still maintain their edge or **they lose that,** and in that expansion play, they let go of their core platform? Those are the things that I am watching personally as well on how Clay is doing in the market.

Plus, obviously, their revenue numbers. If they can keep growing 100% now, it's much easier to grow 100% on a $30 million base than an $80 million-$90 million base. Can they still do it at $200 million? Maybe not 100%, but 80% year-on-year. That would be an interesting thing to watch for as well because the market is attributing. **No one else in the go-to-market space is growing that much**. ZoomInfo is plateauing, **Apollo is growing at a slower rate**. Even the CRMs are not doing well on the stock market so, if they can continue and maintain this positive momentum that's behind them.

Client 00:36:37

Yeah. Seeing if they can maintain the growth rate even at scale. As a last question, is there anything that we did not talk about so far, either specifically about Clay or just about the overall space that you think would be helpful for us to know as we continue to do more work on this research project?

Expert 00:36:55

I think something to dig deeper would be how people other than RevOps and go-to-market engineers are using Clay. How basically SDRs are either up-leveling themselves or not to become a go-to-market engineer. I don't have very deep knowledge in that space, but that could be something interesting to know about, and that would actually determine the success. If more people can use Clay in the market, that becomes their entire community, and then when they go to different companies, they can propagate Clay into their systems as well. That is something that I don't know, but would be really critical to their success as well.

Client 00:37:32

Makes sense. We can look more into that. It's been helpful, so thank you again for making the time for the call today. Otherwise, hope you enjoy the rest of the day.

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